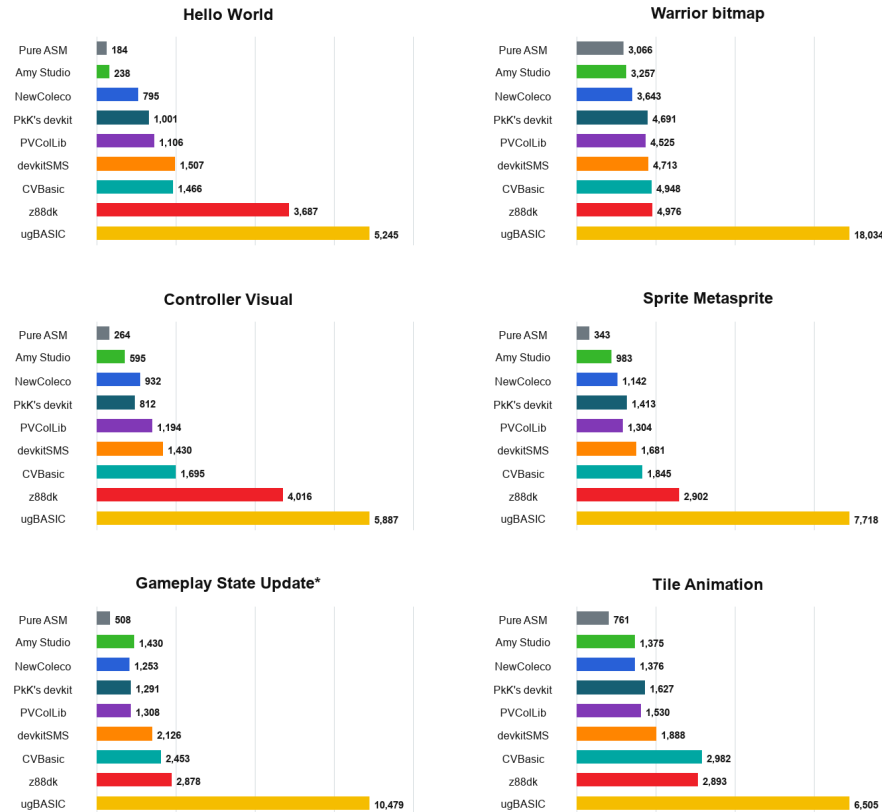


Amy Studio ColecoVision Toolchain Comparison

Measured results, capabilities, compression evidence, and development priorities

Real occupied size, excluding cartridge padding

sizes in bytes (lower is better); * State Update size comparison is provisional



Occupied ROM size excludes cartridge padding. Lower is smaller, not automatically faster or better.

Amy Studio source and GearColeco results

Listings are complete except for bulky sprite patterns and the state-update engine body; both complete sources are in the evidence archive. Screenshots come from GearColeco running each measured ROM for 180 NTSC frames; current integrated debugging uses GearColeco 1.7.0.

Hello World

```
text screen
backdrop sky blue
print centered at 11, "HELLO, WORLD!"
screen on
```



GearColeco screenshot

GearColeco output after 180 NTSC frames

Warrior Graphics II Bitmap

```
picture WarriorPicture:  
  pattern from "@project/warrior.pattern.zx0" codec zx0  
  color from "@project/warrior.color.zx0" codec zx0  
end picture  
  
show picture WarriorPicture
```



GearColeco screenshot

Exact GearColeco output; all eight tools reproduce the same target image

Visual Controller Input

```
text screen
backdrop dark blue
print centered at 8, "CONTROLLER TEST"
print centered at 11, "MOVE OR PRESS A BUTTON"
print centered at 14, "KEYPAD IS PURPLE"
screen on
```

```
InputLoop:
  wait
  if keypad(1) <> 255 then
    backdrop magenta
  elseif joypad(1).fire then
    backdrop light red
  elseif joypad(1).up then
    backdrop light green
  elseif joypad(1).down then
    backdrop dark green
  elseif joypad(1).left then
    backdrop light yellow
  elseif joypad(1).right then
    backdrop cyan
  else
    backdrop dark blue
  end if
  goto InputLoop
```



GearColeco screenshot

GearColeco output at the neutral controller state

Animated Three-Color Metasprite

```

u8 PlayerX = 120
u8 PlayerY = 88
u8 AnimationTick = 0
u8 AnimationFrame = 0

data PlayerMeta metasprite layers 3
  frame 0,15, 4,11, 8,1
  frame 12,15, 16,11, 20,1
end data

' Six 16x16 pattern blocks are included in the evidence archive.
sprites simple
set sprite count 3

MainLoop:
  wait
  if joypad(1).left and PlayerX > 1 then PlayerX -= 1
  if joypad(1).right and PlayerX < 239 then PlayerX += 1
  if joypad(1).up and PlayerY > 1 then PlayerY -= 1
  if joypad(1).down and PlayerY < 175 then PlayerY += 1
  AnimationTick += 1
  if AnimationTick = 8 then
    AnimationTick = 0
    AnimationFrame = 1 - AnimationFrame
  end if
  set metasprite PlayerMeta frame AnimationFrame to PlayerY,PlayerX using sprite 0
  update sprites
  goto MainLoop

```



GearColeco screenshot

A metasprite is one visual actor assembled here from three overlapping hardware sprites

Gameplay State Update

```

record ActorState:
  u8 X
  u8 Y
  u8 Direction
  u8 Timer
  u8 Mode
  u8 Hits
end record

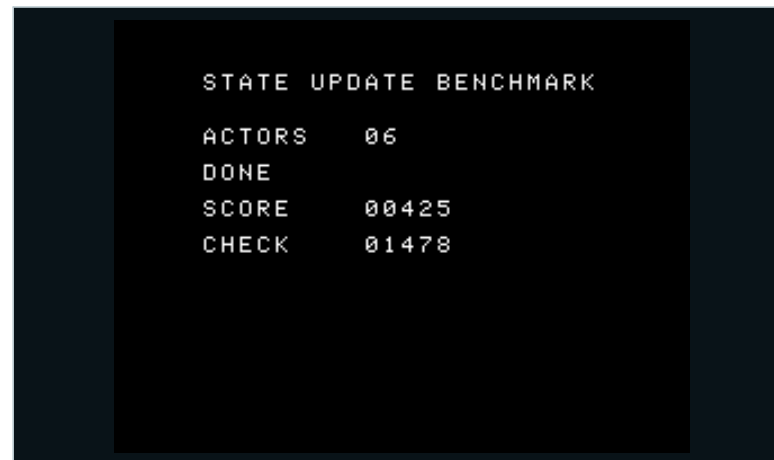
state machine WorldBehavior:
  Running calls UpdateActors
  Bonus calls UpdateBonus
end state machine

ActorState Actors[6]
u16 Score = 0
u16 Checksum = 0

for Tick = 0 to 47
  dispatch WorldMode using WorldBehavior
next

sub UpdateActors:
  for each Actor, ActorIndex in Actors
    ' Movement, timers, modes, collision and score updates.
  next Actor
  if Tick = 23 then WorldMode = WorldBehavior.Bonus
  return

```



GearColeco screenshot

Experimental: 1,460 occupied bytes; exact oracle: state 1, collisions 13, score 425, checksum 1478

Graphics II Tile Animation

```

const StarTile = $80
const ShipFirstTile = $90
u8 StarFrame = 0
u8 ShipFrame = 0

tile screen
backdrop black
nmi off
' Install shared star and two 3x2 ship frames in all Graphics II thirds.
copy StarPattern0 count 8 to vram.pattern + StarTile * 8
copy ShipPatterns count 96 to vram.pattern + ShipFirstTile * 8
copy ShipColors count 96 to vram.color + ShipFirstTile * 8
nmi on

AnimationLoop:
  wait
  Tick += 1
  if Tick & 3 = 0 then
    ' Replace one shared pattern: every star animates together.
    StarFrame = (StarFrame + 1) % 3
    copy StarPatterns[StarFrame * 8] count 8 to vram.pattern + StarTile * 8
  end if
  if Tick & 7 = 0 then
    ' Replace six 3x2 Name Table frames without moving the ships.
    ShipFrame = 1 - ShipFrame
    for Ship = 0 to 5
      put ShipTiles[ShipFrame * 6] frame size 3,2 at ShipX[Ship],ShipY[Ship]
    next
  end if
  goto AnimationLoop

```



GearColeco screenshot

Experimental: 1,378 occupied bytes; continuous shared-pattern and six-ship Name Table animation verified

Pure Z80 assembly reference

Amy Bienvenu published this BIOS-based Hello World on AtariAge in 2010 under the name Daniel Bienvenu. Amy's assembler builds it without optimization, and GearColeco verifies the exact VRAM text after BIOS startup. It occupies 184 bytes.

```
; COLECOVISION - HELLO WORLD!
; By Amy Bienvenu, published as Daniel Bienvenu in 2010
; Original AtariAge sample for TNIASM, assembled here by Amy's Z80 assembler.
CALC_OFFSET    equ $08c0
LOAD_ASCII     equ $1f7f
FILL_VRAM      equ $1f82
MODE_1         equ $1f85
PUT_VRAM       equ $1fbe
TURN_OFF_SOUND equ $1fd6
WRITE_REGISTER equ $1fd9
READ_REGISTER  equ $1fdc
WRITE_VRAM     equ $1fdf
VRAM_NAME      equ $1800
VRAM_COLOR     equ $2000
cpu Z80
org $8000
db $aa,$55
dw 0,0,0,0
dw Start
rst_8:  reti
        nop
rst_10: reti
        nop
rst_18: reti
        nop
rst_20: reti
        nop
rst_28: reti
        nop
rst_30: reti
        nop
rst_38: reti
        nop
jp Nmi
db "HELLO WORLD!/PRINT ON SCREEN/2010"
Start:
im 1
ld hl,$0000
ld de,$4000
xor a
call FILL_VRAM
call MODE_1
call TURN_OFF_SOUND
```



Pure Z80 assembly reference - continued

```

    call LOAD_ASCII
    ld hl,VRAM_COLOR
    ld de,32
    ld a,$f0
    call FILL_VRAM
    call Static_Offset
    call Write_HelloWorld
    ld bc,$01c2
    call WRITE_REGISTER
TheEnd:
    jp TheEnd
HelloWorld:
    db "HELLO WORLD!"
Static_Offset:
    ld de,VRAM_NAME+10
    ret
; Alternative shown in the original tutorial: compute row 0, column 10.
Calculated_Offset:
    ld d,0
    ld e,10
    call CALC_OFFSET
    ld hl,VRAM_NAME
    add hl,de
    ex de,hl
    ret
Write_HelloWorld:
    ld hl>HelloWorld
    ld bc,12
    jp WRITE_VRAM
; Alternative BIOS routine shown in the original tutorial.
Put_HelloWorld:
    ld a,2
    ld hl>HelloWorld
    ld iy,12
    jp PUT_VRAM
Nmi:
    ld hl,VRAM_COLOR
    ld de,32
    ld a,r
    and $f0
    call FILL_VRAM
    call READ_REGISTER
    retn

```

Bienvenu also authored NewColeco. As the AtariAge discussion noted, this compact listing reuses the ColecoVision BIOS font and VDP routines; a private font and runtime would be more independent but larger. Matching hand-written ASM versions now cover all six fixtures and pass their GearColeco oracles. Together they occupy 5,126 bytes versus 7,878 for Amy Studio, a 2,752-byte difference.

The controller ROM fell from 297 to 264 bytes by replacing CONT_SCAN plus a 16-byte keypad table with two BIOS DECODER calls and by storing only the final display color. POLLER remains appropriate when two-sample debounce is required, but its 12-byte result contract and 83-91 executed BIOS instructions per call do not improve this fixture; one DECODER segment takes 29 instructions.

Graphics II compression corpus

All 42 unique 12,288-byte pictures passed exact round-trip checks with every codec. The gallery shows the actual TMS9918 output, the three smallest payloads, and Pletter's rank when it falls outside the top three. Exomizer also needs a 226-byte ROM decoder and 156 bytes of CPU RAM. Amy Studio reserves that workspace at a 256-byte boundary; its generated address varies and must not overlap other RAM.

Rank	Codec	Payload total	Decoder	First-use places (pictures)				
				1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
1	Exomizer 2	161,374	226	21	12	2	3	1
2	ZX0	166,556	133	21	18	1	2	0
3	DAN2	166,923	212	0	0	7	13	10
4	DAN3	167,186	205	0	0	16	5	11
5	DAN1	167,240	205	0	3	4	9	16
6	MegaLZ	171,016	162	0	0	1	1	1
7	aPLib Compact	171,484	244	0	0	0	0	0
8	Pletter	171,751	212	0	0	0	0	0
9	ZX7	171,788	136	0	0	2	9	3
10	BitBuster	172,941	166	0	0	0	0	0
11	ZX1	176,562	127	0	4	5	0	0
12	ZX2	177,582	115	0	5	4	0	0
13	LZF	193,412	117	0	0	0	0	0
14	Nibble	214,555	115	0	0	0	0	0
15	MDK-RLE	253,859	46	0	0	0	0	0

Corpus gallery 1-6

**Cake**

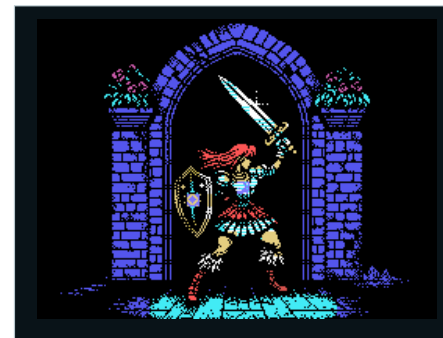
Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

- 1. Exomizer 2: 2,935 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 2,958 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 2,999 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 3,108 bytes

**Commando**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

- 1. Exomizer 2: 5,206 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 5,310 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 5,312 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 5,508 bytes

**Warrior**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 2,821 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 2,849 bytes
- 3. DAN3: 2,891 bytes
- ... 10. Pletter: 2,988 bytes

**Barbarian**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 4,165 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 4,229 bytes
- 3. DAN3: 4,286 bytes
- ... 5. Pletter: 4,339 bytes

**421 Title**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

- 1. ZX0: 1,055 bytes
- 2. Exomizer 2: 1,060 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 1,067 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 1,110 bytes

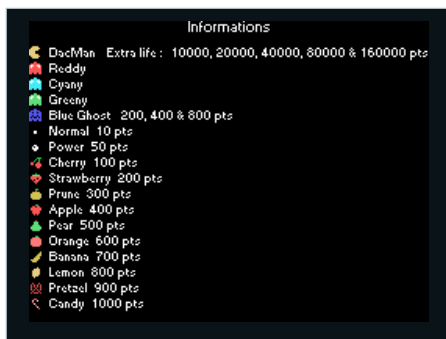
**Dacman Title**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

- 1. Exomizer 2: 967 bytes
- 2. DAN1: 969 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 972 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 1,035 bytes

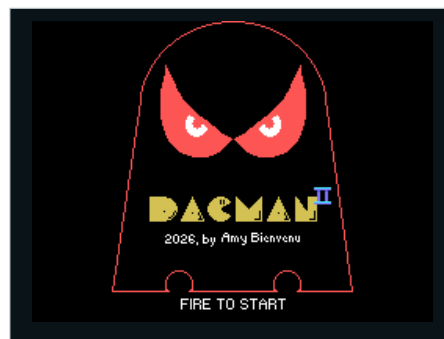


Corpus gallery 7-12

**Dacman Information**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

1. Exomizer 2: 1,248 bytes
2. ZX0: 1,260 bytes
3. DAN2: 1,273 bytes
- ... 10. Pletter: 1,361 bytes

**Dacman 2 Title**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

1. Exomizer 2: 1,142 bytes
2. DAN2: 1,168 bytes
3. DAN1: 1,171 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 1,231 bytes

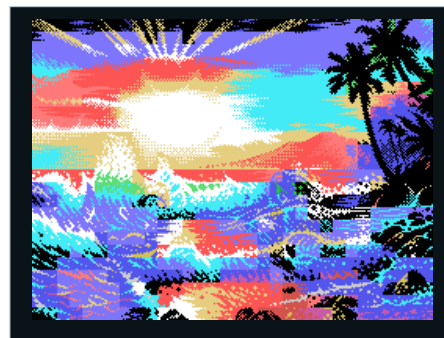
**Le Chateau du Dragon**

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

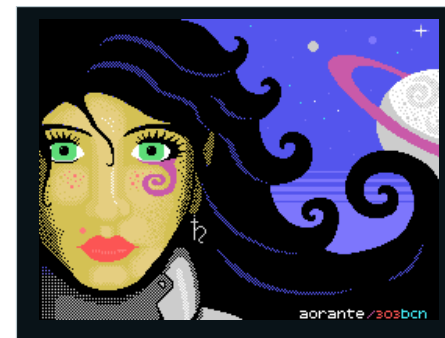
1. Exomizer 2: 1,613 bytes
2. ZX0: 1,636 bytes
3. DAN1: 1,651 bytes
- ... 10. Pletter: 1,730 bytes

**Almighty God - Aliquis Acuario Ingens**

1. Exomizer 2: 7,099 bytes
2. ZX0: 7,234 bytes
3. DAN3: 7,271 bytes
- ... 7. Pletter: 7,447 bytes

**Aloha (ArtField 2010, 1)**

1. Exomizer 2: 6,754 bytes
2. DAN1: 6,989 bytes
3. DAN2: 6,991 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 7,199 bytes

**Aorante - Lady Saturn**

1. Exomizer 2: 3,497 bytes
2. DAN3: 3,653 bytes
3. DAN2: 3,657 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 3,810 bytes

Corpus gallery 13-18



Bejeweled
Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco
1. Exomizer 2: 1,519 bytes
2. ZX0: 1,564 bytes
3. DAN1: 1,594 bytes
... 9. Pletter: 1,661 bytes





Anime Portrait
1. Exomizer 2: 2,098 bytes
2. DAN2: 2,157 bytes
3. DAN3: 2,162 bytes
... 8. Pletter: 2,265 bytes



Band Wagon Logo
Vanja Utne / Mermaid
1. Exomizer 2: 2,155 bytes
2. ZX0: 2,172 bytes
3. DAN2: 2,183 bytes
... 6. Pletter: 2,243 bytes





Bat Character
Vanja Utne / Mermaid
1. Exomizer 2: 945 bytes
2. ZX0: 980 bytes
3. DAN1: 987 bytes
... 8. Pletter: 1,051 bytes





Blue Portrait
Vanja Utne / Mermaid
1. Exomizer 2: 5,902 bytes
2. ZX0: 6,073 bytes
3. DAN2: 6,097 bytes
... 7. Pletter: 6,224 bytes





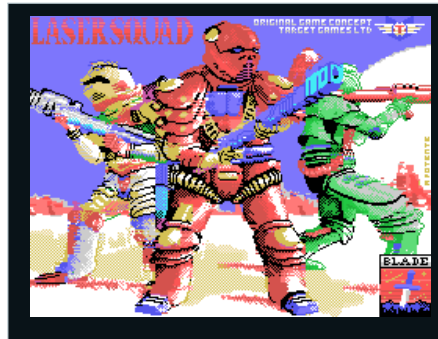
Fantasy Camp
Vanja Utne / Mermaid
1. Exomizer 2: 5,996 bytes
2. DAN2: 6,138 bytes
3. DAN1: 6,147 bytes
... 8. Pletter: 6,317 bytes



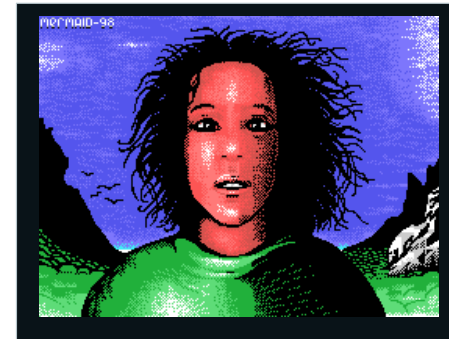
Corpus gallery 19-24

**Feliz Navidad**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 3,998 bytes
- 2. DAN3: 4,149 bytes
- 3. ZX0: 4,154 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 4,300 bytes

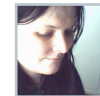
**Laser Squad**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 7,357 bytes
- 2. DAN2: 7,488 bytes
- 3. DAN1: 7,494 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 7,774 bytes

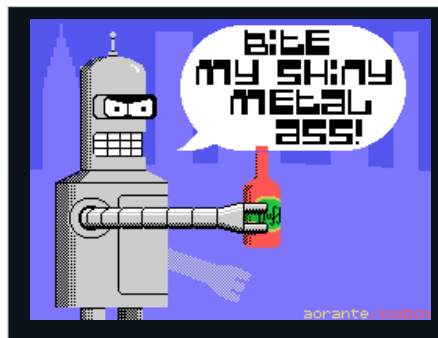
**Mermaid Portrait**

Vanja Utne / Mermaid

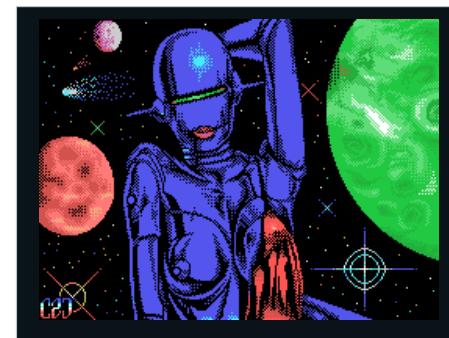
- 1. Exomizer 2: 5,848 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 6,050 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 6,070 bytes
- ... 7. Pletter: 6,196 bytes

**Reservoir Dogs**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 2,208 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 2,315 bytes
- 3. DAN3: 2,316 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 2,414 bytes

**Robot Quote**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 1,990 bytes
- 2. DAN3: 2,076 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 2,097 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 2,217 bytes

**Space Soldier**

- 1. Exomizer 2: 5,522 bytes
- 2. DAN2: 5,649 bytes
- 3. DAN1: 5,661 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 5,886 bytes

Corpus gallery 25-30

**Turban Character**

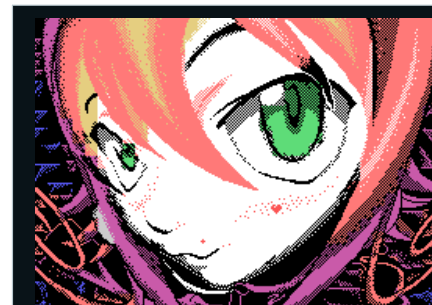
Vanja Utne / Mermaid

1. Exomizer 2: 7,629 bytes
2. DAN1: 7,908 bytes
3. DAN2: 7,911 bytes
- ... 7. Pletter: 8,170 bytes

**Mad Cow**

Vanja Utne / Mermaid

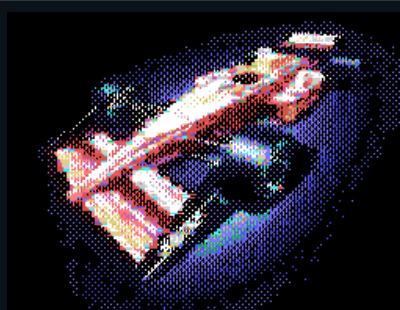
1. Exomizer 2: 2,125 bytes
2. DAN3: 2,171 bytes
3. DAN2: 2,180 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 2,273 bytes

**Blair (Chaos Constructions 2009, 6)**

1. Exomizer 2: 5,140 bytes
2. ZX0: 5,372 bytes
3. DAN3: 5,374 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 5,491 bytes

**Bugs (Demobit 1995, 4)**

1. Exomizer 2: 2,032 bytes
2. DAN3: 2,091 bytes
3. ZX0: 2,107 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 2,191 bytes

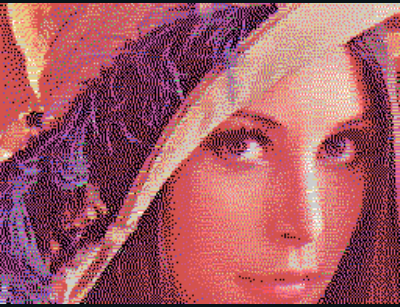
**F1 SPP**

1. Exomizer 2: 4,169 bytes
2. DAN3: 4,277 bytes
3. DAN2: 4,278 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 4,462 bytes

**Kozmonaut (Forever 7, 7)**

1. Exomizer 2: 2,694 bytes
2. DAN3: 2,780 bytes
3. ZX0: 2,792 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 2,892 bytes

Corpus gallery 31-36



lenna

- 1. Exomizer 2: 9,071 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 9,400 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 9,425 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 9,556 bytes



Maze Maniac

Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco
(contributor)

- 1. Exomizer 2: 2,625 bytes
- 2. DAN3: 2,709 bytes
- 3. ZX0: 2,713 bytes
- ... 7. Pletter: 2,817 bytes



Mona Lisa

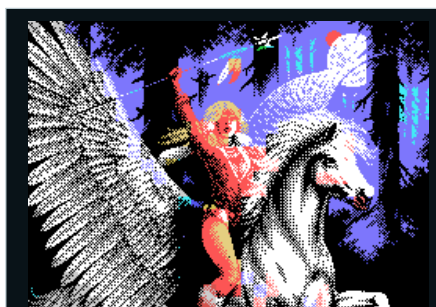
- 1. Exomizer 2: 9,208 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 9,426 bytes
- 3. DAN3: 9,490 bytes
- ... 5. Pletter: 9,640 bytes



ROM File Edition

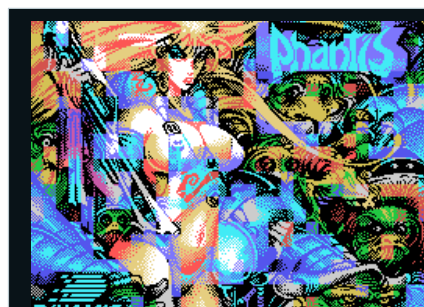
Amy Bienvenu / NewColeco

- 1. ZX0: 901 bytes
- 2. Exomizer 2: 904 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 909 bytes
- ... 9. Pletter: 960 bytes



Pegasus (Millennium 1903, 1)

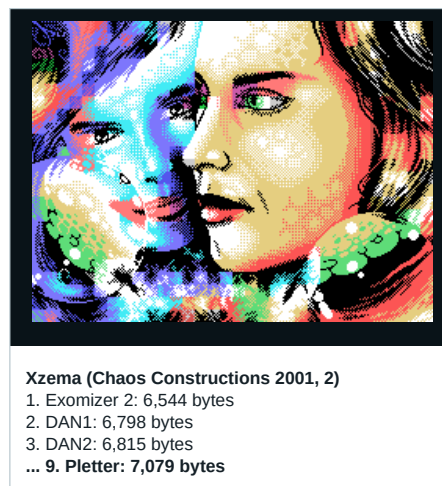
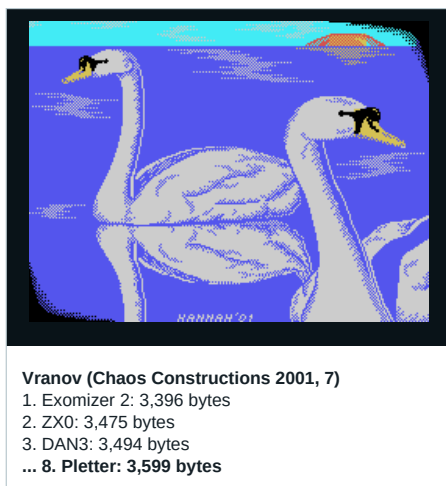
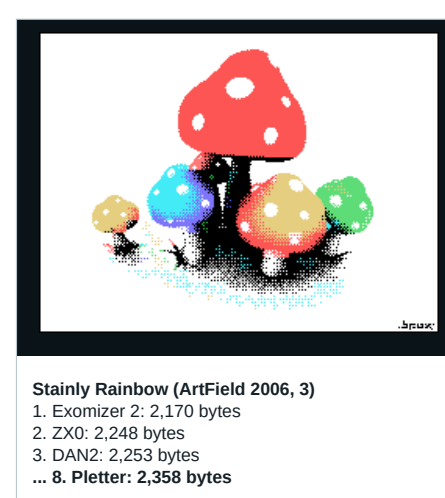
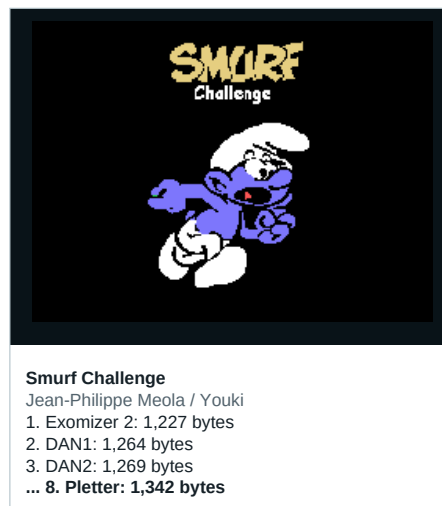
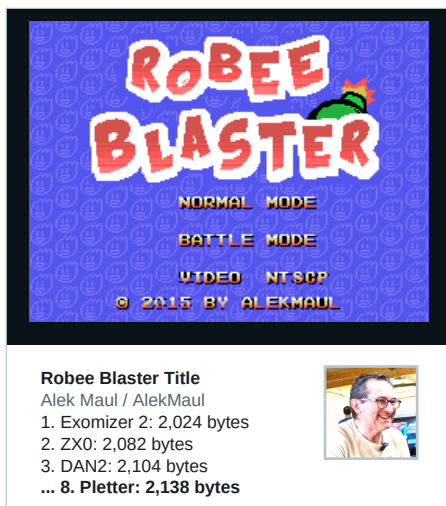
- 1. Exomizer 2: 6,168 bytes
- 2. ZX0: 6,405 bytes
- 3. DAN1: 6,415 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 6,544 bytes



Phantis (3BM OpenAir 2014, 1)

- 1. Exomizer 2: 8,109 bytes
- 2. DAN1: 8,387 bytes
- 3. DAN2: 8,388 bytes
- ... 8. Pletter: 8,599 bytes

Corpus gallery 37-42



Updated: 2026-09-28

Method

This comparison separates four kinds of evidence:

- **Runtime verified:** compiled for ColecoVision and checked in an emulator or self-test.
- **Build verified:** the ColecoVision source, header, library, or generated assembly was inspected.
- **Documented:** claimed by the tool's official documentation, but not yet measured here.
- **Unverified:** available somewhere in the wider tool, but not proven for ColecoVision.

Amy Studio combines a language and IDE; the others are mainly compilers or C kits. IDE-only features are listed separately from language capabilities.

The eight solutions

Solution	Primary approach	ColecoVision position
Amy Studio	ColecoVision-first Amy language and browser IDE	Original 1 KB RAM, BIOS-aware, no extra hardware by design
CVBasic	Portable integer BASIC cross-compiler	Mature native target; optional MegaCart and SGM support
z88dk +coleco	General Z80 C toolchain	C compiler, assembler, linker, libraries, and app packaging
ugBASIC	Portable retro BASIC compiler	Declared target with common high-level multimedia vocabulary
devkitSMS + sglib_cv	SDCC C plus compact game libraries	ColecoVision adaptation of the SG/SMS development workflow
PVCoLib	ColecoVision-focused SDCC C library and devkit	Native VDP, controller, sprite, sound, music, and compression APIs
NewColeco	Historical SDCC C, CRTCV, CVLIB, and GETPUT 1.1	Amy's pre-Studio ColecoVision workflow and direct ancestor of current techniques
PkK's devkit	Philipp Klaus Krause's ColecoVision SDCC C devkit, using the libcv / libcvu libraries	Small link-only runtime with native graphics, input, sprites, and RLE+Huffman assets

Reproducible six-sample ROM suite

The suite builds six runnable programs with all eight solutions:

1. a visible Hello World;
2. the Warrior Graphics II bitmap picture;
3. a visual controller monitor;
4. an animated, controller-driven three-color metasprite;
5. a deterministic six-actor gameplay state update;
6. a Graphics II star field and six animated 3x2 tile ships.

A **metasprite** combines hardware sprites into one actor. This test overlaps three 16x16 layers (white, yellow, black), below the four-sprites-per-scanline limit.

The build scripts create 48 ROMs, grouped under **build/competition.tools/report-five-tool-sample-sizes.ps1** records occupied sizes; dedicated GearColeco tests verify the bitmap, controller, metasprite, and deterministic state-update oracles.

Validated optimization settings

Solution	Setting used	Observation
Amy Studio	Experimental	Saved 1 byte on Bitmap and 2 on Controller versus Balanced; Hello was unchanged
CVBasic 0.9.2	Normal compiler; TMSColor -z -p2 for Bitmap	No stronger compiler optimization switch was exposed; Pletter is used for its bitmap
z88dk	+co1eco -03; ZX0 for Bitmap	Coleco-safe direct-to-VRAM port of z88dk's ZX0 core; ZX7, MDKRLE, and raw baselines remain measured
ugBASIC 1.18	Default maximum of 16 peephole passes	Explicit 32- and 64-pass builds produced the same Hello binary
devkitSMS / SDCC 4.5	--opt-code-size --max-allocs-per-node 100000 on the program and SGLib	Saved 60 bytes on Bitmap; Hello and Controller were unchanged
PVColLib 1.6.0 / bundled SDCC	--opt-code-size --max-allocs-per-node 20000	Official build flags; linked only referenced library modules
NewColeco / SDCC 2.9.0	--std-c99; original prebuilt libraries plus historical DAN2	Historical stack ABI required; the exact DAN2 bitmap is 626 bytes smaller than its GETPUT MDKRLE baseline
PkK's devkit / SDCC 4.5	--opt-code-size --max-allocs-per-node 25000	Its libcv / libcvu libraries link only referenced modules; the higher allocator limit prevents an SDCC IY miscompile in the state fixture

These are the most size-oriented **native settings successfully validated in this study**. They are not claims about every release or possible project configuration. No other toolchain's output passed through Amy's optimizer or MDL. Amy Experimental serves this size test; Balanced remains its default.

Real occupied size, excluding cartridge padding

Sample	Pure ASM*	Amy Studio	NewColeco	PkK's devkit	PVColLib	devkitSMS	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC
Hello World	184	238	795	1,001	1,106	1,507	1,466	3,687	5,245
Warrior bitmap	3,066	3,257	3,643	4,691	4,525	4,713	4,948	4,976	18,034
Controller Visual	264	595	932	812	1,194	1,430	1,695	4,016	5,887
Sprite Metasprite	343	983	1,142	1,413	1,304	1,681	1,845	2,902	7,718
Gameplay State Update*	508	1,430	1,253	1,291	1,308	2,126	2,453	2,878	10,479
Tile Animation	761	1,375	1,376	1,627	1,530	1,888	2,982	2,893	6,505
Six-sample total*	5,126	7,878	9,141	10,835	10,967	13,345	15,389	21,352	53,868

Pure ASM is a diagnostic lower-level baseline, not a ninth high-level toolchain. Its State Update fixture validates the complete headless workload but omits Amy Studio's additional status display.

Measured bitmap baselines: z88dk RAW 14,293 bytes, MDKRLE 5,911, ZX7 5,115, and ZX0 4,976; NewColeco GETPUT/MDKRLE 4,269 and DAN2 3,643. All reproduce both VRAM tables and 49,152 pixels. ugBASIC's **COMPRESSED** and **NONE** Warrior builds are identical at 18,034 bytes: MSC1 was discarded, and its RLE image branch is C128-only.

Legacy payloads are MDKRLE 3,687, DAN1 2,903, DAN2 2,897, and DAN3 2,891 bytes. DAN2 stays linked: DAN3 saves six payload bytes before decoder cost, while DAN2 is validated end to end.

Occupied includes header, runtime, code, and data, but excludes cartridge padding. Sources are: assembled length (Amy), **ROM_END-\$8000** (CVBasic), unpadded binary (z88dk), generated code+data (ugBASIC), Intel HEX span above **\$8000** (devkitSMS/PVColLib), and complete linked binary (NewColeco).

Runtime and comparability verdict

Sample	Runtime result	Verdict
Hello World	Nine ROMs complete 180 GearColeco frames	Stable startup
Warrior bitmap	Nine native pipelines render the same 256x192 image	0 / 49,152 pixels differ
Controller Visual	Eight pass injected neutral, keypad, UP, FIRE, and release states	Partial: ugBASIC does not update VDP R7
Sprite Metasprite	Nine pass the same VRAM and sprite-table checks	Exact patterns, layers, and priority
Gameplay State Update	Nine match world state 1, 13 collisions, score 425, checksum 1478	Exact deterministic oracle
Tile Animation	Nine continuously animate shared patterns and six 3x2 Name Table frames	Exact VRAM tables, no stray ship tiles, animation continues after 100 frames

The State Update row is behavior-validated but not yet a strict code-size comparison: Amy Studio also draws a title, progress text, score, and checksum, while the current NewColeco fixture runs the state simulation without equivalent display output. Its sizes remain evidence artifacts, not a code-generator ranking, until matched headless and visible variants are built. PVCollib and NewColeco use \$F0 transparent-background text so VDP R7 changes remain visible; controller logic and occupied size are unchanged.

BIOS-assisted pure Z80 assembly baseline

Amy Bienvenu published this TNIASM-style **HELLO WORLD!** tutorial on AtariAge in 2010 under the name Daniel Bienvenu; she is also the author of NewColeco. Amy's assembler builds it without optimization, and GearColeco verifies the exact twelve Name Table bytes after BIOS startup. The program occupies **184 bytes**, measured by **tools/test-pure-asm-hello.mjs**.

The historical listing is compact because it reuses the BIOS font and VDP routines. Matching hand-written ASM implementations now exist for all six fixtures, use the same assets and observable behavior allowed to Amy Studio, and pass their GearColeco runtime oracles.

Sample	Pure ASM	Amy Studio	ASM difference
Hello World	184	238	-54
Warrior bitmap	3,066	3,257	-191
Controller Visual	264	595	-331
Sprite Metasprite	343	983	-640
Gameplay State Update	508	1,430	-922
Tile Animation	761	1,375	-614
Six-sample total	5,126	7,878	-2,752

The controller fixture originally occupied 297 bytes using BIOS **CONT_SCAN**, cartridge-side decoding, and a 16-byte keypad table. The optimized 264-byte version calls BIOS **DECODER** once for joystick/left FIRE and once for keypad/right FIRE, removes the lookup table, and stores only the final display color. It passes neutral, keypad, held direction, FIRE, and release tests. BIOS **POLLER** remains useful when its two-sample debounce is required, but its 12-byte result contract and 83-91 executed BIOS instructions per call are not a free size optimization; one **DECODER** segment takes 29 instructions.

The ASM total is a lower-level baseline, not evidence that assembly is universally preferable. It measures the price of language/runtime convenience and identifies concrete optimization opportunities. The State Update caveat still applies: its ASM fixture validates the complete headless state workload but does not reproduce Amy's extra status display.

PASS, **PARTIAL**, and exclusions describe only the named fixture, tool version, build options, and oracle used here. They do not establish that a toolchain lacks another valid API, release, or project-specific solution. Reproducible evidence should replace a status whenever broader support is demonstrated.

Native bitmap paths are Amy/z88dk ZX0, CVBasic Pletter, ugBASIC resources, devkitSMS aPLib, PVColLib RLE, PkK's devkit using **libcv** RLE+Huffman, and NewColeco DAN2. All framebuffers are exact despite equivalent internal table encodings. PVColLib Pletter failed VRAM validation and is excluded.

For z88dk, MDKRLE reaches VRAM at frame 93, ZX0 at 132, and ZX7 at 138. ZX0 saves 935 bytes versus MDKRLE and 139 versus ZX7; MDKRLE is faster. A transplanted SMS aPLib path failed and is excluded; native devkitSMS aPLib remains exact with frame interrupts disabled during decompression.

The initial ugBASIC mismatch came from the wrong RGB palette. With its target palette, all four corpus pictures render exactly.

Observations supported by this suite

- Amy produces the smallest measured ROM for Hello, Controller, and this exact bitmap fixture (3,257 versus CVBasic's 4,948 bytes for the bitmap).
- Portable C/BASIC runtimes add visible fixed cost, but complete games may scale differently.
- Cartridge length includes packaging; a padded 32 KB file is not necessarily a 32 KB program.
- Smaller results count only after runtime validation; this finite suite cannot establish a universal winner.
- RAM, worst-frame cycles, build latency, sound, sprite pressure, and gameplay remain separate tests.

Preliminary capability matrix

Legend: **Yes** = verified or explicit target support; **Partial** = manual or narrower support; **Pending** = must still be proven specifically on ColecoVision. * marks a benchmark adaptation written here, not a native ColecoVision direct-to-VRAM path supplied by that solution.

This compact matrix covers six current general-purpose toolchains. NewColeco and PkK's devkit are documented separately below from their measured fixtures and inspected APIs.

Capability	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS / SGLib_CV	PVCoLib
8/16-bit integers	Yes	Yes	Yes	Documented	Yes, through SDCC	Yes, through SDCC
32-bit integers	Yes, runtime tested	No native BASIC type	Yes	Documented; target cost pending	Yes, through SDCC	Yes, through SDCC
Fixed-point	Yes, 8.8 and 16.16	No	Library/manual	Documented; target proof pending	Manual C/library code	Manual C/library code
Records/structures	Yes	No	Yes	Documented custom types	Yes	Yes
2D arrays	Yes	No native 2D syntax	Yes	Documented	Yes	Yes
RAM overlays	Yes, first-class	Manual	C union/manual layout	Pending	C union/manual layout	C union/manual layout
Functions with values and returns	Yes	Limited BASIC procedures/DEF FN	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Inline Z80 assembly	Yes	Yes	Yes	Documented	Yes	Yes
TMS9918 screen and tile operations	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes, target proof incomplete	Yes	Yes
Hardware sprite API	Yes	Yes	Low-level/library	Yes, exact target surface pending	Yes	Yes, 32-entry SAT
Four-sprite scanline mitigation	Yes, stable ranges and flicker	Yes, sprite flicker	Manual	Pending	Manual/library-dependent	Yes, NMI sprite swapping
Keypad	Yes	Yes	Library/manual	Pending	Yes/target library	Yes, both ports
Spinner / Roller Controller	Yes	Yes	Not confirmed	Pending	Not confirmed	Yes, both ports
Held, pressed, and released input	Yes	Held; edges are manual	Manual	Manual edges over JOY	Yes, computed from NMI snapshots	Manual edges over NMI snapshots
Coleco PSG sound	BIOS tables, Tiny Sound, DSOUND	Sound/music commands	Sound libraries	Sound commands, target proof pending	PSGLib_CV	BIOS-style sound tables and sequenced music
Direct-to-VRAM compression	Fifteen active codecs, including Exomizer 2 and MegaLZ	Pletter	RAM APIs; ZX0, ZX1, ZX2, and ZX7 benchmark VRAM ports	Resource conversion; RAM-oriented compression	ZX7 and aPLib	RLE, Pletter, DAN1/2/3
ROM banking	Intentionally no	Yes	Yes	Pending	SMS workflow has banking; CV support pending	MegaCart tools and examples
Source-level Coleco debugger	Integrated	External emulator	External debugger/emulator	External or IDE-dependent	External debugger/emulator	External debugger/emulator
Rewind, breakpoints, VRAM/RAM inspection	Integrated	External	External	External	External	External
Graphics editors and project assets	Integrated	Separate tools	Separate tools	Conversion-oriented IDE/tools	Separate asset tools	gfx2col and separate asset tools
Automated ROM behavior tests	Integrated project pipeline	Not supplied as one system	Can be assembled manually	Not established	Not established	Not established

Detailed language and runtime evidence

Data model

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Integer widths	Explicit signed/unsigned 8/16/32	8/16, signed or unsigned	C 8/16/32	Backend defines signed/unsigned 8/16/32	SDCC C 8/16/32	SDCC C 8/16/32
Fractional math	fixed , ufixed , fixed32 , fp5	None	C/library float and fixed libraries	VT_FLOAT exists; Coleco cost pending	SDCC float/manual fixed	SDCC float/manual fixed
Decimal scores	Packed BCD 1-12 digits	Manual	Manual/library	Manual	Manual/library	Manual/library
Aggregates	Nested records, record arrays	None	struct/union	Typed arrays and internal resource types; user-structure surface pending	struct/union	struct/union
Multidimensional arrays	Primitive 2D arrays	One-dimensional only	Native C	Typed arrays; dimensional coverage pending	Native C	Native C
Mutually exclusive RAM	First-class overlays/scenes	Manual aliases	union/linker/manual	Banking/resource allocator; no equivalent proven	union/linker/manual	union/linker/manual
Dynamic strings	Deliberately fixed-buffer oriented	Mostly literals/printing	C strings and allocation libraries	First-class strings	C strings; risky in 1 KB RAM	C strings; risky in 1 KB RAM

Amy's data model directly addresses stock ColecoVision game RAM through overlays and scenes. C offers general-purpose unions and pointers but leaves lifetime analysis and debugger-aware overlay tracking to the project. ugBASIC has a broad internal type system; its ColecoVision ROM/RAM cost still requires fixture-specific compilation and validation.

Control, timing, and code organization

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Procedures/functions	Typed values, ref , returns, recursion	Procedures without value parameters; DEF FN expression macros	Full C	Procedures/functions documented	Full C	Full C
State machines	Typed zero-RAM dispatch	Manual SELECT /labels	Manual enum/switch/table	Manual control constructs	Manual enum/switch/table	Manual enum/switch/table
VBlank	wait , frame hooks, timers	WAIT, ON FRAME	HALT/NMI hooks/manual	WAIT VBL, EVERY , timers	SG_waitForVBlank , frame handler	vdp_waitvblank , user nmi hook
Parallel animation	Not yet first-class	Manual	Manual/interrupt	ANIMATION, ANIMATE, MOVE , paths and multitasking source present	Manual frame service	Manual NMI/frame service
Inline assembly	Amy ASM bridge	ASM, CALL, USR	Native inline/external ASM	Supported	SDCC inline/external ASM	SDCC inline/external ASM

ugBASIC provides a useful reference for a future optional Amy animation service. Its broader abstraction also illustrates costs Amy would need to measure: state variables, thread handles, paths, delays, signals, and background-preservation storage. Amy should evaluate those ideas only when exact RAM and cycle costs are visible and the entire service disappears when unused.

TMS9918 graphics and sprites

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	SGlib_CV	PVCoLib
Text/tile/bitmap modes	Coleco-specific commands and editors	Modes and direct VRAM commands	Generic TMS9918/graphics libraries	TMS9918 backend and resource conversion	Tile, bitmap, VDP and VRAM functions	Text, bitmap, VDP and VRAM functions

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	SGlib_CV	PVCoLib
Pixel/line/circle	Yes, programmer controls NMI-safe batching	Yes	Generic graphics	TMS9918 drawing backend	Pixel/bitmap helpers	Low-level VRAM/bitmap support
Sprites	Fields, clipping helpers, movement, editor	Define/place sprites	Low-level/library	Sprite conversion and TMS9918 operations	SAT builder, clipping, finalize/copy	32-entry SAT, update and fast-update APIs
Collision	Hitboxes, tile groups, hardware status	VDP status/manual	Hardware/manual	Hardware collision/hit backend	VDP status/manual	<code>spr_collide</code> hitboxes and VDP status
Scanline overflow	Explicit flicker and stable priority ranges	Sprite flicker	Manual	No verified policy	Manual ordering	<code>spr_getentry</code> swaps sprites each NMI
Asset authoring	Integrated bitmap/tile/sprite/frame editors	Separate tools	Separate tools	Automatic image conversion	External asset tools	<code>gfx2col</code> and external tools

Amy Studio provides an integrated authoring/debugging workflow and explicit TMS9918 policy. ugBASIC provides automatic modern-image conversion, while SGlib_CV offers a compact C SAT workflow. These are different workflow priorities, not interchangeable measures of quality.

Controllers

Capability	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	SGlib_CV	PVCoLib
Two directions/fire ports	Yes	Yes	<code>joystick(1/2)</code>	<code>JOY(0/1)</code> backend	NMI snapshots both ports	<code>joypad_1/2</code> , four fire bits
Two keypad ports	Yes	Yes	<code>joystick(3/4)</code> high byte	<code>SCANCODE</code> path; exact port behavior pending	<code>SG_readCVNumPad</code>	<code>keypad_1/2</code>
Pressed/released	First-class per property	Manual previous state	Manual previous state	Manual previous state	First-class status helpers	Manual previous-state comparison
Spinner/Roller	Yes	Yes	Not found in Coleco target	Not found yet	Not found	<code>spinner_1/2</code> , reset and enable APIs
Automatic minimal backend	Yes, capability selected	Runtime-integrated	Linker includes referenced routines	Deployment system includes used modules	Library/NMI input service	Linker extracts referenced modules

Sound and music

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
SN76489 tones/noise	BIOS sound tables and direct formats	SOUND	PSG libraries/manual ports	SN76489 backend	PSGlib_CV	BIOS-style sound tables
Sequenced music	BIOS format and Tiny Sound	MUSIC , simple/full players	External/player libraries	MUSIC backend	PSG streams; looping/status	NMI-serviced music sequences
Concurrent SFX	Coleco table areas/Tiny Sound	Channel depends on music mode	Library-dependent	Pending measurement	PSG SFX channels and frame service	Four music areas plus sound areas 5+ for SFX
Digital samples	DSOUND	No first-class support	Manual/custom	Pending	No first-class support found	No first-class support found
Authoring	Integrated table/SFX editors, two-channel Tiny Sound sequencer, MIDI capture	Note-oriented BASIC source	External VGM/tools	Source/resource conversion	External PSG tools	External table/asset tools

Amy Studio exposes the widest set of playback formats examined in this study, while CVBasic keeps a particularly concise music source syntax. Amy Studio can inspect and edit BIOS sound tables, audition steady/fade/echo envelopes, and capture note, velocity, and duration from Web MIDI. Its two-channel Tiny Sound sequencer edits notes, duration, tempo, envelopes, vibrato, and arpeggios with byte-exact project write-back. Remaining work is workflow polish and broader browser-versus-PSG fidelity measurement, not basic sequence editing.

Compression evidence

Compression must be scored as **compressed payload + linked decompressor**, with destination and cycles. Counting a host compressor without a ColecoVision decoder is invalid.

All fifteen integrated Amy codecs were also compiled as separate Balanced ROMs and run for 180 NTSC frames in GearColeco. Every ROM reproduced Warrior's 6,144 Pattern bytes and 6,144 Color bytes exactly in VRAM. Run `node tools/test-integrated-codec-vram-roms.mjs` to repeat this check.

Direct-to-VRAM speed ranking

This benchmark measures two complete 6,144-byte Amy decompression commands (Pattern and Color) with NMI disabled. GearColeco counts exact Z80 master-clock cycles between executable markers and then verifies all 12,288 VRAM bytes. The samples are the mechanically selected most-compressible, median, and least-compressible corpus pictures. Run `node tools/benchmark-codec-vram-cycles.mjs`.

Rank	Codec	Decoder bytes	Average cycles	Observed range	NTSC frames	PAL frames
1	MDK-RLE	46	445,166	397,701-480,470	7.45	6.24
2	LZF	117	2,228,378	1,699,652-2,499,555	37.30	31.23
3	Nibble	115	2,500,641	1,109,539-4,605,294	41.86	35.04
4	BitBuster	166	2,534,837	2,200,323-2,848,558	42.43	35.52
5	ZX2	115	2,640,553	2,523,782-2,813,703	44.20	37.00
6	ZX1	127	2,649,233	2,542,465-2,824,788	44.35	37.12
7	ZX0	133	2,776,094	2,593,812-2,917,877	46.47	38.90
8	aPLib Compact	244	2,882,985	2,038,419-3,910,905	48.26	40.40
9	Pletter	212	3,011,986	2,593,248-3,420,132	50.42	42.21
10	ZX7	136	3,045,957	2,646,525-3,421,800	50.99	42.68
11	DAN3	205	3,260,654	2,819,207-3,514,505	54.58	45.69
12	MegaLZ	162	3,545,056	3,003,617-4,081,177	59.35	49.68
13	DAN2	212	3,683,858	2,806,792-4,725,242	61.67	51.62
14	DAN1	205	3,809,391	2,827,513-5,013,133	63.77	53.38
15	Exomizer 2	226	5,443,661	3,379,601-8,078,445	91.13	76.28

Frame values are time equivalents (**59, 736** cycles NTSC; **71, 364** PAL), not VBlank waits. Speed and ROM-size rankings are separate: choose using compressed payload plus decoder size, then check whether the measured loading time suits the game. Nibble and aPLib vary substantially by input, which is why Amy Studio should present per-asset estimates rather than one universal winner.

Solution	Confirmed formats	Direct VRAM status	Integrated selection
Amy Studio	Exomizer 2, ZX0, ZX1, ZX2, aPLib, MegaLZ, ZX7, Pletter, DAN1/2/3, LZF, BitBuster, MDK-RLE, Nibble	ColecoVision paths, including workspace-based formats	Browser comparison/import and asset metadata
CVBasic	Pletter	DEFINE CHAR/COLOR/SPRITE/VRAM PLETTER	Explicit source keyword
z88dk	ZX0/1/2/7 and aPLib families, multiple speed/size decoders	Stock decoders target RAM; ZX0 and ZX7 Coleco VRAM adaptations verified here	Manual headers/linking and host tools
ugBASIC	MSC1 and RLE types in compiler source	MSC1 image fallback verified; RLE is not implemented for Coleco	Resource compiler can choose compression when it wins

Solution	Confirmed formats	Direct VRAM status	Integrated selection
SGlib_CV / SMSlib routine	ZX7 and aPLib	ZX7 API; aPLib direct-to-VRAM exact with frame IRQ disabled	Manual host compression and C asset inclusion
PVColLib	RLE, Pletter, DAN1/2/3	RLE direct-to-VRAM verified exactly here; other paths remain separate candidates	gfx2col conversion and C asset inclusion
NewColeco	GETPUT 1.1 MDK-RLE	Direct-to-VRAM verified exactly on Warrior	External CVPaint/asset tools and C data inclusion

z88dk's public ZX0 integration request dates from February 2021, consistent with ZX0/ZX7 being available there by spring 2021. Its bundled compressor identifies itself as ZX0 v1.5 and emits the official classic v1 format. Amy Studio's current **zx0** codec emits the later official v2 format by default. The streams are intentionally not interchangeable. z88dk's stock routines target RAM; this benchmark adds only ColecoVision TMS9918 direct-to-VRAM adaptations and validates their output independently.

Codec naming and integration policy

Candidate	Honest Amy name	Current evidence	Integration condition
ZX0	ZX0 / codec zx0	Existing v2 browser encoder and Coleco VRAM decoder	Keep as the default
ZX1	ZX1 / codec zx1	Byte-identical browser encoder; exact GearColeco VRAM and cycle proof	Integrated and measured
ZX2	ZX2 / codec zx2	Exact corpus round-trip, five-profile VRAM proof, and cycle proof	Integrated and measured
aPLib	aPLib / codec aplib	Bidirectional appack parity and exact Amy/GearColeco VRAM ROM	Integrated; keep NMI-safe upload and attribution explicit
MegaLZ	MegaLZ / codec megalz	Independent DEC40-compatible encoder; exact corpus round-trip and GearColeco VRAM/cycle proof	Integrated and measured
Exomizer 2	codec exomizer	Independent browser encoder, exact 42-picture round trip, five-profile VRAM proof, and cycle proof	Integrated; 226-byte decoder; compiler-assigned 256-byte-aligned AMY_EXOMIZER_TABLE reserves 156 bytes through address +\$009B
MSC1	MSC1	ugBASIC discards it for Warrior when it gives no gain	Useful Coleco corpus wins and a VRAM strategy

A host compressor alone is insufficient. An Amy codec requires round-trip tests, exact GearColeco VRAM output, decoder cost, explicit destination semantics, malformed-stream failure tests, documentation, and attribution. RAM-only APIs and locally written VRAM ports must remain labelled.

Current measured status: Amy Studio integrates the broadest codec selection examined in this ColecoVision workflow; devkitSMS has verified ZX7 and aPLib paths, PVColLib has a verified RLE path, and CVBasic has a concise Pletter path. On Warrior and Cake, official ZX1, ZX2, and aPLib do not beat Amy's ZX0 first-use ROM size. aPLib nevertheless cuts the devkitSMS Warrior ROM from 13,680 raw bytes to 4,713 occupied bytes. ZX1 is now an integrated Amy codec with a 127-byte direct-to-VRAM decoder and exact runtime and cycle proofs. ugBASIC's MSC1 is a valid comparison candidate, not ten separate codecs, but it does not improve the Warrior resource.

What MSC1 actually is

MSC1 is ugBASIC's compact block-repetition format, not another general ZX0-style LZ codec. A stream contains literal blocks of 1-127 bytes and back-references that repeat one four-byte sequence up to 32 times. The back-reference offset is limited to roughly 1 KB, and a zero token ends the stream. This favors maps, records, planar graphics, and other data with repeated groups of four bytes.

The current Z80 decoder is simple and Apache-2.0 licensed, but writes to ordinary memory with **LD (DE), A**. On a stock 1 KB ColecoVision it cannot directly expand a 6 KB pattern or color table. More importantly, ugBASIC's generic **LOAD("file") COMPRESSED** implementation actually invokes MSC1 when the target declares expansion banks. The standard Coleco target does not, so the keyword is accepted but ignored there. Five raw/compressed resource pairs produced byte-identical generated code and data. This is therefore not presently a

general Coleco capability comparable to Amy's direct-to-VRAM codecs.

MSC1 can still be selected by some ugBASIC image/resource conversion paths. A fair evaluation of that narrower feature needs a direct-to-VRAM proof and a mixed corpus: bitmap tables, name tables, tile sets, sprite frames, level maps, record arrays, and sound data. Only candidates that reduce **payload + linked decoder**, round-trip exactly, and pass GearColeco should be added.

aPLib integration status

aPLib has three useful pieces already available locally: the official host compressor, Amy's JavaScript beam-search encoder, and direct-to-VRAM Z80 implementations in z88dk/devkitSMS. The devkitSMS routine uses the Coleco-compatible **\$BF/\$BE** VDP ports, but is explicitly unsafe while the display is active and lacks the Coleco BIOS protection used by **SG_decompressZX7toVRAM**.

The JavaScript encoder now passes bidirectional differential checks against official aPLib on real TMS9918 tables and structured, incompressible, repetitive, short, and boundary-sized data. Its exact-cost planner produces 3,054 bytes for Cake and 2,973 for Warrior, versus official raw payloads of 3,088 and 2,975. Official **appack** still wins some individual resources, so neither encoder universally dominates.

Amy now ships the browser encoder and a 244-byte compact public-domain SMSlib-derived ColecoVision VRAM decoder. **decompress aplib Source to vram.pattern** accepts a raw **.aplib** stream and the existing VRAM upload wrapper provides the same NMI-safe contract as other Amy LZ codecs. A compiled Amy ROM reconstructed Warrior's 6,144-byte pattern and color tables exactly in GearColeco under all five optimization profiles. The Balanced test ROM occupied 3,517 bytes with 2,973 compressed data bytes. The official aPLib executable is used only for differential testing and is not redistributed.

The first reproducible size results and the rules for the cross-tool runtime comparison are in **competition/benchmarks/compression/README.md**. On two real 12,288-byte TMS9918 pictures, ZX0 has the smallest Amy first-use ROM total after its current 133-byte decompressor estimate is included. The separate GearColeco cycle benchmark supplies the speed evidence; size and speed remain independent selection criteria.

Memory, ROM size, and banking

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVColLib
Stock 1 KB RAM focus	Core design, RAM estimates, overlays	Yes, global/static model	Configurable CRT/C runtime	Backend manages runtime/resources	SDCC/static library model	SDCC/static library model
Dead helper elimination	Capability-driven generation	Compiler-generated runtime	Linker sections/libraries	Deploy-on-use modules and target optimizer	Linker library extraction	Linker library extraction
Optimizer	Five profiles plus runtime corpus	Z80 optimizer and peepholes	sccz80/zsdcc optimizers	Coleco-specific optimizer source	SDCC optimizer/peepholes	SDCC size optimization
Beyond 32 KB	Deliberately excluded	MegaCart up to 1 MB	Coleco banking/toolchain	Target support not yet proven	MegaCart and banked functions documented	MegaCart tools and example verified
Debug-aware RAM names	Yes, including overlay aliases	Assembly labels	Map/debug symbols	Generated symbols	Map symbols	Map symbols

Banking is an established capability in CVBasic, z88dk, devkitSMS, and PVColLib. Amy Studio keeps stock, unbanked cartridges as its current release baseline; MegaCart support is documented as a future architecture project and is not counted in these measurements.

Stock baseline versus expanded hardware

The size and runtime ranking above targets an original ColecoVision: TMS9918A video, SN76489 sound, 1 KB system RAM, Coleco BIOS, and an unbanked cartridge whenever possible. Optional hardware is credited separately because it changes the machine available to the programmer:

Extension	Verified or documented advantage	Scope in this comparison
MegaCart / bank switching	CVBasic, z88dk, devkitSMS, and PVColLib can exceed the normal cartridge space	Valid capability; excluded from stock-ROM size ranking
F18A	PVColLib provides dedicated APIs and examples for enhanced video hardware	Valid for modified or compatible clone systems; out of scope for ColecoVision-exclusive titles
SGM / AY-3-8910-compatible sound	CVBasic and PVColLib provide explicit SGM paths; PVColLib also detects SGM RAM and ADAM	Valid expansion/clone capability; out of scope for the stock sound ranking
Extra RAM	Available through SGM, ADAM, and compatible clones depending on the tool/runtime	Report separately; never count it as stock 1 KB RAM

This separation reports extended-hardware capabilities on their own terms while keeping the stock-hardware measurements comparable.

Development experience

Area	Amy Studio	CVBasic	z88dk	ugBASIC	devkitSMS	PVCoLib
Browser IDE	Integrated	No official integrated IDE	No	IDE/web options advertised	No	No
Source breakpoints	Yes	External emulator	External debugger	IDE-dependent/unverified	External emulator	External emulator
ASM stepping/rewind	Integrated GearColeco workflow	External	External	External	External	External
RAM/VRAM/symbol inspection	Integrated	External	External	External	External	External/map symbols
Cycle profiling	Integrated	External/manual	External/manual	Unverified	External/manual	External/manual
Project graphics editors	Integrated/configurable	Separate tools	Separate tools	Resource conversion/IDE	Separate tools	gfx2col /separate tools
Automated ROM tests	Corpus, checkpoints, runtime harness	Not integrated	Buildable manually	Not established	Not established	Not established

This is a measured distinction of Amy Studio's current workflow. A fair comparison should label command-line-only Amy scripts separately from features directly accessible in the IDE.

Amy Studio emphasizes ColecoVision integration

Amy Studio's principal distinction in this study is not one isolated keyword. It connects source editing, asset conversion, compression, assembly optimization, ROM execution, source breakpoints, rewind, memory and VRAM inspection, controller configuration, profiling, and automated tests in one ColecoVision-focused workflow. Its overlays, typed state machines, BCD, fixed-point support, runtime-checked wide integers, collision helpers, and BIOS-aware input selection are also substantial language-level strengths.

CVBasic emphasizes portability and established BASIC simplicity

CVBasic has a compact QBasic-like surface, a mature ColecoVision backend, many complete game examples, spinner support, sprite flicker support, music commands, and optional ROM banking. It also targets many related machines. This comparison did not identify direct CVBasic equivalents for Amy's records, overlays, wide numeric model, integrated debugger, or combined asset/debug pipeline; future versions or external project tools may cover parts of that workflow.

Official source: nanochess/CVBasic

z88dk emphasizes general C and toolchain breadth

z88dk provides full C data structures, pointers, mature compilers, assemblers, linkers, libraries, compression utilities, and many Z80 targets. This flexibility also exposes more low-level choices to the programmer. Its generic graphics and library facilities require target-specific validation before they can be compared directly with a ColecoVision-focused Amy command.

Official source: z88dk/z88dk

ugBASIC emphasizes a broad portable high-level vocabulary

ugBASIC documents nonblocking animation, movement, paths, image conversion, sprites, sound, and many modern BASIC constructs. This makes it especially relevant when considering future Amy animation ergonomics. However, its multi-target manual describes capabilities that can differ by backend. Generated ColecoVision Z80 and runtime behavior must be measured before declaring those features equivalent.

Official sources: [ugBASIC site](https://ugbasic.org/) and spotlessmind1975/ugbasic

devkitSMS offers a compact C game-library workflow

devkitSMS combines SDCC with small game-oriented libraries and asset tools. **SGLib_CV** and **PSGLib_CV** make it relevant to ColecoVision even though much of the surrounding documentation is SMS-oriented. Only APIs present in the ColecoVision headers and libraries should enter this comparison.

The local **SGLib_CV** source confirms that its ColecoVision NMI scans direction/fire mode and numpad/right-trigger mode, preserves current and previous states, and implements **SG_getKeysStatus**, **SG_getKeysPressed**, **SG_getKeysHeld**, **SG_getKeysReleased**, and **SG_readCVNumPad**. These input capabilities are source-verified for ColecoVision, not inferred from SMSlib.

Official source: sverx/devkitSMS

PVColLib offers broad ColecoVision-focused C APIs

PVColLib is a ColecoVision-focused SDCC library and development kit. Its official repository includes the compiler toolchain, VDP and controller APIs, sprites, sound/music support, compression routines, MegaCart, SGM, Phoenix, and F18A facilities. The three stock fixtures here use its official build flags and linked library. Local headers and examples verify both controller ports and keypads, both spinners, 32 sprites, NMI sprite swapping, hitbox collisions, BIOS-style sound tables, sequenced music with concurrent SFX areas, direct VRAM operations, MegaCart, SGM, Phoenix, and F18A support. Its RLE bitmap path was validated byte-for-byte in VRAM; the available Pletter and DAN paths are not credited with a benchmark size until a compatible stream passes the same exact runtime test.

Official source: alekmaul/pvcollib

NewColeco provides a historical baseline

The recovered SDCC branch uses Amy's original **CRTCv**, **CVLIB**, and GETPUT 1.1 libraries. Their prebuilt ASxxxx objects require the historical stack-parameter ABI, **.o** object naming, and first-object linker output convention. The comparison now pins SDCC 2.9.0 #5416 (March 2009). Modern SDCC 3.8/4.5 builds can link and boot while silently miscalling stack-ABI routines; the PutPixel fixture changed from an ABI-incompatible 4,937-byte modern build to a runtime-correct 1,211-byte ROM with SDCC 2.9. Details and the checksum-verified installer are documented in **newcoleco-sdcc-toolchain-compatibility.md**.

NewColeco results count only after behavior-specific GearColeco validation. Warrior is decompressed directly to VRAM with GETPUT's MDK-RLE routine and matches all 12,288 target table bytes and all 49,152 pixels.

PkK's devkit also originates in the SDCC 2.x era, but its **libcv** 0.28 library is a different case: its current headers explicitly apply **__sdccall(0)** to assembly-facing APIs, and the benchmark rebuilds the selected library objects and callers together with SDCC 4.5. NewColeco instead links preserved binary libraries without that source-level ABI bridge and must remain on SDCC 2.9. Compiler age alone is therefore not the rule; declared calling convention plus runtime proof is.

This is not an unrelated additional competitor: it is the documented historical ancestor of Amy Studio. Its 795-byte Hello, 3,643-byte DAN2 bitmap, and 932-byte controller monitor show that the old BIOS-aware and link-only-what-is-used philosophy was already effective. Amy Studio improves those results while adding the Amy language, integrated assets, diagnostics, and debugging; this describes an evolution of workflow rather than a judgment on the earlier kit.

The original NewColeco website is no longer available. The surviving public references are the [January 2018 devkit archive](#), the [AtariAge 2018 update](#), and the complete [AtariAge history](#).

PkK's devkit combines compact linking with deliberately low-level APIs

Philipp Klaus Krause's devkit uses **libcv** / **libcvu**, links only used SDCC modules, and completes all six fixtures. Its six-sample total is 10,835 bytes, the third-smallest total in this specific suite. The deterministic state update averages 8,315 cycles with a 10,412-cycle worst frame. Its native RLE+Huffman bitmap path reproduces all 12,288 Warrior bytes exactly, but the 2,934-byte payload also needs a 514-byte tree/configuration, about 411 linked decoder bytes, and 19 bytes of runtime state. Across 42 pictures its median payload is 4,098 bytes and it usually ranks 14th or 15th among 17 measured methods. These results make PkK's devkit useful evidence for compact C linking and shared-codebook research; they do not position either toolchain as a general replacement for the other.

Official resources: [installation tutorial](#), [libcv reference](#), and [ColecoVision.eu](https://colecovision.eu).

Next measurement suite

The comparison becomes stronger as equivalent game behaviors are implemented eight times. Current status and order:

1. **Controller snapshot: complete.** Seven toolchains pass injected neutral, keypad, direction, fire, and release states; ugBASIC's VDP R7 update remains the documented exception.

2. **Sprite/metasprite stress: complete.** Eight toolchains build and boot the shared fixture.

Amy's native metasprite path is runtime-equivalent, uses zero permanent RAM, preserves explicit layer priority, and is smaller than the manual renderer in all five profiles.

3. **Tile animation: complete.** Eight ROMs animate shared patterns and 3x2 Name Table frames; GearColeco verifies every pattern, color, tile position, animation phase, and final state.

4. **State update: complete.** Eight ROMs run the same actor array, collision checks, timers, and state dispatch oracle.

5. **Sound authoring: functional and still evolving.** BIOS commands and Tiny Sound sequences can be inspected, auditioned, edited, imported, and written back; UX and audio-parity QA continue.

6. **Compression: payload and cycle suites complete.** Fifteen codecs have exact VRAM proof; representative streams now include linked decoder bytes and GearColeco cycle measurements.

7. **Visible Hello: complete.** Keep it separate from the minimal runtime fixture so font/text costs remain explicit.

All benchmark Amy listings are available in Amy Studio under **Benchmarks**. The evidence archive groups the matching source and loadable ROM for every tool. Measurements use occupied bytes rather than padding, and a smaller result counts only when the shared runtime oracle passes.

Ranked Amy gap plan

Rank	Open work	Status	Value	Effort	Risk
1	Complete full-song multichannel sound authoring and emulator-parity QA	Functional foundation	High	Medium	Medium
2	Extend cooperative animation only when evidence justifies it	Prototype validated	High	Medium	Medium
3	Prototype MegaCart banking before choosing public syntax	Feasible, deferred	High for large games	Large	High

MegaCart feasibility is now documented in `amy-megacart-bank-switching-feasibility.md`. The current assembler has logical **ORG** support but lacks independent physical ROM placement, bank-aware symbols, capacity diagnostics, and bank-aware debugging. The first acceptable step is a development-only 128 KB GearColeco fixture, not a public language command.

The libcv-inspired codec study is complete and rejected for Amy Studio. One shared model was 5,174 bytes larger than specialized models across the 42-picture corpus. An independent generic RLE-plus-canonical-Huffman candidate passed exact round trips for all 84 Pattern/Color blocks and adversarial data, but occupied 183,675 bytes versus ZX2's 177,582 before adding a new Z80 decoder. The implementation remains development-only historical evidence, not a selectable Studio codec.

Completed gaps and next concrete work

Specialized graphics experiments

The principal rankings stay focused on common game workloads. The evidence archive separately preserves the PutPixel Motion experiment derived from sverx's SGLib_CV example: seven toolchains pass the motion, two-controller, and Name Table oracle; ugBASIC is reported as **PARTIAL** because native **PLOT** works while FIRE reads remain neutral in this fixture. A second, unranked study keeps Oscar Toledo's CVBasic pixel/line/circle example beside its working Amy Studio port. Other ports will be added only after equivalent output and GearColeco framebuffer checks exist.

Completed and runtime-guarded:

- exact eight-tool runtime oracles for metasprites, state updates, and tile animation;
- native metasprites, protected-priority flicker, editable previews, and cooperative animation using two RAM bytes, no hidden NMI work, and 4-5 fewer ROM bytes than the former manual loop;
- complete 2D arrays across locals, records, parameters, and overlays, with bounds diagnostics and five-profile runtime proof;
- fifteen direct-to-VRAM codecs measured for size, cycles, and RAM across 42 pictures; Warrior uses 3,257 bytes with ZX0 and 3,319 with Exomizer 2;
- indexed **put frame** corruption fixed by the Tile Animation VRAM oracle, plus Sound Workspace v1 with sequencer editing, undo, import, Web MIDI, and 24 unit/browser/compiler/GearColeco tests;
- 155 five-profile display tests across numeric and qualified operands. Adaptive **u8** formatting saves 212 corpus bytes; explicit Amy digits match hand-written Z80 at 498 bytes and 1,905 cycles.